needed to be done by force. It was not difficult to convince Central Europeans to support this way of thinking and even to join the American military campaign, although they must have been aware of the naivety of the belief that their path to democracy could be replicated in a completely different social setting, where dictators appeared to be the best guardians of delicate balances between peoples and religious factions, and the Enlightenment was almost unheard of.

On the other side of Eastern Europe, Putin's reading of the aftermath of the invasion of Iraq was different, and, in a certain way, definitely more realistic. For him, the military campaign was a proof that the 'West's self-proclaimed pursuit of democracy and freedom only brings instability and suffering in its wake.'[104] This analysis by the Russian leader is not important in as much as it is true, but more to the extent in which it is false, namely, the implication that the West should sit idle and not try to promote its values. In the eyes of Putin, his own understanding of events was confirmed by the 2003 Rose Revolution in Georgia, marking a pro-Western turn, and a similar Orange Revolution in Ukraine in 2004: instability came dangerously close to Russia's front yard.

Central Europe's hasty embrace of the US approach was certainly not welcome in France and the rest of the Continent, except with some conservative governments. And while everyone was aware of the largely opportunistic nature of such a position on the part of Central European governments, there began to emerge a new gap, previously unknown, between Europe's East and West. On the one side of this gap was Western Europe, for a long time now at peace, enjoying an unparalleled level of prosperity created by the post-war socio-economic consensus of the mainstream political forces of left and right, based on the narrative of World War II as a great conflict between liberal thought and Fascism. In this narrative, Communism (if you discount the Soviet contribution in the war itself) had only a side role; it was seen more as an aberration of liberal democracy, rather than its true opponent. After all, there was no lack of admirers of the Soviet Union and Communist ideas in post-war Europe, not only among extremist leftist organisations like *Brigate Rosse* in Italy or *Baader-Meinhof-Gruppe* in Germany. In any event, Communism was believed to be won over and gone with the fall of the Berlin Wall. There was no need to be worried about it anymore. The menace of the revolution,